

The Slow Cooker Cookbook for Seniors - Printable Charts

From *The Slow Cooker Cookbook for Seniors* by Laura Bennett (Oro Enigma Publishing). Print as many copies as you need; the sheets are sized for the fridge door.

The Times Chart

For a 1.5-to-3.5-litre pot filled half to two-thirds. A bigger pot, or a smaller amount, cooks faster. Check at the early end the first time.

Food	Prepared how	LOW	HIGH	Notes
Beef				
Stewing steak, diced	3 cm pieces, floured	8 h	4 to 5 h	Falls apart when done
Brisket or topside joint, 700 g	Whole, on onions	8 to 9 h	not recommended	Slices with a fork; 63C / 145F, rest
Lean mince	Broken up, in sauce	6 to 7 h	3 to 4 h	71C / 160F
Meatballs	Raw, in sauce	5 to 6 h	3 h	Do not stir for the first hour
Chicken and turkey				
Thighs, boneless skinless	Whole or halved	6 to 7 h	3 to 4 h	The forgiving cut; 74C / 165F
Breasts	Whole, in sauce	4 to 5 h	2 to 3 h	Dries if longer; strips 4 h LOW
Drumsticks, skin off	Whole	6 h	3 h	74C / 165F at the bone
Whole chicken, 1.4 kg	Breast up, on onions, no liquid	6 to 7 h	4 h	74C / 165F in the thigh; 3.5 L pot
Turkey mince	Broken up, in sauce	6 to 7 h	3 to 4 h	74C / 165F
Turkey breast steaks	In sauce	4 h	2 h	Lean: keep short
Pork and lamb				
Pork shoulder, diced or 600 g piece	For pulling	8 to 9 h	not recommended	HIGH makes it stringy
Pork loin steaks	In sauce	4 to 5 h	2 to 3 h	Lean: keep short; 63C / 145F
Pork tenderloin	Whole, in sauce	4 h	2 h	63C / 145F, rest
Gammon joint, 600 g	Poached in liquid	6 to 7 h	3 to 4 h	Salty; once a fortnight
Sausages	Browned first, in sauce	6 h	3 h	71C / 160F
Bacon, chopped	In soups and pots	6 h	3 h	Seasoning as much as meat

Lamb shoulder or neck, diced	3 cm pieces	7 to 8 h	4 h	Falls apart when done
Lamb leg steaks	In sauce	5 to 6 h	3 h	63C / 145F
Fish and seafood				
Salmon fillets	Poached in liquid	1 to 1.5 h	45 min	63C / 145F, flaking; no longer
White fish (cod, haddock) chunks	Into a cooked sauce	last 40 min on HIGH		Push under the sauce
Cooked prawns	Into a cooked sauce	last 10 min on HIGH		Just to heat through
Mussels, cleaned	Into a cooked sauce	last 20 min on HIGH		Discard any that stay shut
Soups				
Vegetable or chicken soup	Chunks and stock	6 to 7 h	3 to 4 h	Blend at the end if liked
Lentil or split pea soup	Rinsed, no soaking	6 to 8 h	3 to 4 h	Stir hard at the end
Bean soup (canned beans)	Drained and rinsed	6 to 7 h	3 to 4 h	Canned only
Vegetables and grains				
Potatoes, quartered	In liquid, at the bottom	7 to 8 h	4 h	Even sizes
Jacket potatoes	Pricked, in foil, no water	7 to 8 h	4 h	Knife slides in
Carrot, swede, parsnip	Thick slices or chunks	7 to 8 h	4 h	At the bottom
Sweet potato	Cubes	5 to 6 h	3 h	Softer than potato
Butternut squash	Cubes	5 to 6 h	3 h	For soup, blend
Onions, sliced	With butter, for a jam	8 to 10 h	5 h	Lid off the last hour
Peppers, courgette, aubergine	Chunks	4 to 6 h	2 to 3 h	Softer; lid off at the end to thicken
Mushrooms	Sliced or whole	4 to 6 h	2 to 3 h	Give up water
Cabbage, red	Shredded, with vinegar	6 h	3 h	Stir once
Leeks	Thick slices	4 h	2 h	Silky

Peas, sweetcorn, green beans, spinach	Frozen or fresh	last 10 to 15 min		Keep their colour
Pearl barley	Rinsed, in stock	6 to 7 h	3 to 4 h	The slow-cooker grain
Red lentils	Rinsed, in liquid	6 h	3 h	Collapse to a puree
Green or brown lentils	Rinsed, in liquid	6 h	3 h	Hold their shape
Split peas	Rinsed, no soaking	6 to 8 h	3 to 4 h	Collapse
Canned beans, any	Drained and rinsed	6 to 7 h	3 to 4 h	Never dried without the boil
Dried kidney beans	Soaked and BOILED 10 min first	6 to 8 h	3 to 4 h	Chapter 4
Pasta, dried	Into liquid	last 20 to 30 min on HIGH		Small shapes; or macaroni cheese 1.5 to 2 h HIGH
Rice, white	In milk for pudding only	3 to 4 h	2 h	For savoury rice, cook separately
Steel-cut oats	In water and milk, overnight	7 to 8 h		Never rolled oats overnight
Dumplings	On top of a stew		last 40 min on HIGH	Do not lift the lid
Puddings				
Stewed apples, pears, plums	Chunks, little water	4 h	2 h	Mash or leave
Whole apples, stuffed	Cored, in a little water	3 to 4 h	2 h	
Poached pears	In juice	3 h	1.5 h	Firm pears
Rice pudding	Pudding rice in milk	3 to 4 h	2 h	Stir once
Sponge pudding in a bowl	Bowl in water		2 h	Water halfway up the bowl
Self-saucing pudding	Batter and sauce in the pot		2 to 2.5 h	Tea towel under the lid
Crumble	Fruit under, oats over		2 to 2.5 h	Lid propped the last 30 min
Bread and butter pudding	Custard over bread	3 h	1.5 to 2 h	Just set

Dried fruit compote	In juice	3 h	1.5 h	Keeps a week
Other				
Chicken stock from bones	Bones, vegetables, water	10 to 12 h		Strain, cool fast
Tomato sauce	Cans, onion, garlic	6 h	3 h	Lid off to thicken
Baked beans (canned beans)	In tomato sauce	6 h	3 h	
Hot chocolate	Milk and cocoa	2 h	1 h	Whisk once

The Conversion Card

Any covered, wet dish converts: less liquid, more time.

In the oven or on the hob, it takes	In the slow cooker on HIGH	On LOW
15 to 30 minutes	1 to 2 hours	4 to 6 hours
30 to 45 minutes	2 to 3 hours	6 to 8 hours
50 minutes to 3 hours	4 to 6 hours	8 to 12 hours

Your recipe says	In the slow cooker
Oven or hob, 15 to 30 minutes	HIGH 1 to 2 hours, or LOW 4 to 6
Oven or hob, 30 to 45 minutes	HIGH 2 to 3 hours, or LOW 6 to 8
Oven or hob, 50 minutes to 3 hours	HIGH 4 to 6 hours, or LOW 8 to 12
A bottle of stock, a pint of liquid	A third to a half less
Milk, cream, cheese, yogurt in the sauce	The last 20 minutes, or off the heat
Fresh herbs	At the end
Pasta or rice in the dish	Pasta the last 20 to 30 minutes on HIGH; rice cooked separately
A glass of wine	A splash, or stock
Serves four	Make four; freeze two
One hour on HIGH	Equals two hours on LOW

Five Freezer Bags

Raw ingredients bagged for two; thaw overnight in the fridge (never from frozen into the pot); the liquid and the potatoes go in on the day.

Bag	In the bag	Add on the day	Slow cooker
Chicken and root casserole (C1)	4 thighs floured, carrots, parsnip, onion, garlic, thyme, mustard	Potatoes, 1.5 cups stock	LOW 6 to 7 h
Chicken curry (C2)	4 thighs, onion, garlic, ginger, curry powder, half can tomatoes, sweet potato	Half cup stock; coconut milk and spinach at the end	LOW 6 h
Beef stew (B1, half)	300 g beef floured, onion, carrots, garlic, puree, thyme, bay	Potatoes, 1 cup stock, Worcestershire	LOW 8 h
Turkey chilli (C6, half)	1 portion mince, onion, pepper, garlic, spices, puree	Can tomatoes, can beans, quarter cup stock	LOW 6 to 7 h
Lamb tagine (P7, half)	1.5 portions lamb, onion, garlic, ginger, spices, apricots, honey	Can tomatoes, can chickpeas, half cup stock	LOW 8 h

Safe Temperatures and the Ten Rules

Food	Temperature
Chicken and turkey	74C / 165F
Mince, sausages, meatballs	71C / 160F
Beef, pork and lamb joints, steaks, chops	63C / 145F, rest 3 minutes
Fish	63C / 145F, flaking
Eggs, set	71C / 160F
Reheated leftovers	74C / 165F, bubbling through
WARM setting	Above 60C / 140F; two hours

The ten rules: thaw meat first; fill half to two-thirds; switch on and leave on; keep the lid down; canned beans, or dried ones boiled hard for ten minutes; cook to the temperature, not the clock; cool and refrigerate leftovers within two hours; never reheat in the slow cooker; WARM for two hours, not all evening; if the power failed while you were out, throw the food away.

The Reheating Rules

Slow-cooked food reheats beautifully, but not in the slow cooker: it takes too long to get through the danger zone. A page, not a recipe.

1. From the fridge: a pan, a splash of water, medium heat, stirring, until it bubbles right through (74C / 165F on the thermometer); or the microwave, covered, stirred halfway, until steaming throughout.
2. From the freezer: thaw overnight in the fridge first, or microwave on defrost, then as above. A frozen block can go straight into a pan on low with a lid and a splash of water, stirred as it melts.
3. Once only: reheat a portion once and eat it. Do not reheat the whole pot and return the rest to the fridge.

Remember: The WARM setting is for holding cooked food for up to two hours, not for reheating cold food.

The Weekly Planner

Day	Into the pot (time and setting)	Dinner	Lunch tomorrow / freezer
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

My Pot's Times

Every pot is different. The book's times are the starting point; write your own beside them.

Dish	The book says	My pot
Beef stew, diced	LOW 8 h / HIGH 4 to 5 h	
Chicken thighs in sauce	LOW 6 to 7 h / HIGH 3 to 4 h	
Chicken breast in sauce	LOW 4 to 5 h	
Whole chicken, 1.4 kg	LOW 6 to 7 h	
Pulled pork	LOW 8 to 9 h	
Red lentil soup	LOW 6 h / HIGH 3 h	
Jacket potatoes	LOW 7 to 8 h / HIGH 4 h	
Poached salmon	LOW 1 to 1.5 h	
Rice pudding	LOW 3 to 4 h / HIGH 2 h	
Self-saucing pudding	HIGH 2 to 2.5 h	